was not an ideal but a by-product of the government's inability to exert totalitarian control.

The second characteristic of dictatorial networks is that they assume the centre is infallible. They therefore dislike any challenge to the centre's decisions. Soviet propaganda depicted Stalin as an infallible genius, and Roman propaganda treated emperors as divine beings. Even when Stalin or Nero made a patently disastrous decision, there were no robust self-correcting mechanisms in the Soviet Union or the Roman Empire that could expose the mistake and push for a better course of action.

In theory, a highly centralised information network could try to maintain strong self-correcting mechanisms, like independent courts and elected legislative bodies. But if they functioned well, these would challenge the central authority and thereby decentralise the information network. Dictators always see such independent power hubs as threats and seek to neutralise them. This is what happened to the Roman Senate, whose power was whittled away by successive Caesars until it became little more than a rubber stamp for imperial whims.[2] The same fate befell the Soviet judicial system, which never dared resist the will of the Communist Party. Stalinist show trials, as their name indicates, were theatre with preordained results.[3]

To summarise, a dictatorship is a centralised information network, lacking strong self-correcting mechanisms. A democracy, in contrast, is a distributed information network, possessing strong self-correcting mechanisms. When we look at a democratic information network, we do see a central hub. The government is the most important executive power in a democracy, and government agencies therefore gather and store vast quantities of information. But there are many additional information channels that connect lots of independent nodes. Legislative bodies, political parties, courts, the press, corporations, local communities, NGOs and individual citizens communicate freely and directly with one another so that most information never passes through any government agency and many important decisions are made elsewhere. Individuals choose for themselves where to live, where to work and whom to marry. Corporations make their own choices about where to open a branch, how much to invest in certain projects and how much to charge for goods and services. Communities decide for themselves about organising charities, sporting events and religious festivals. Autonomy is not a consequence of the government's ineffectiveness; it is the democratic ideal.